

Battle of Wesnoth



Genre: RTS (real time strategy)

Game play

This is one of the less common strategy games that concentrate heavily on combat skills, with hardly any emphasis on resources. While the 'turn-based' game play might be a bit of a turn-off, it also boasts of a unique set of mechanics that allow for a broader range of conflicts. Moreover, there is no tech tree, or even player-constructed buildings. The only resource is gold that can be collected by occupying more villages.

The terrain plays a key role in game play. In most cases it is the sole factor in how likely a unit's attack will actually land on its target. Also, different terrains offer differing amounts of protection for different units. Mountain tiles offer great protection for Elven fighters, but almost none for mounted units like knights. Sometimes the player has to make choices between chasing down decimated units or heading for the high ground in preparation for the next attack wave. Often, unit positioning is such a key element that the game feels more like chess than anything else.



The battles are often close and exciting, despite the turn-based nature of play. Sometimes entire conflicts can rest on the fate of a single unit. Sometimes smaller armies can defeat significantly larger ones with good tactics. The best thing about this game is that cheap tactics are non-existent or ineffective. There is no opportunity for tower raping or siege tank abuse. Even in the most dire situations, hope is not lost if one's army can escape to find cover and regroup.

Video

The graphics in this game are 2D sprites, with nothing but sliding around and fancy animation to serve as eye candy. That being said, they are some of the most polished graphics of any tile-based 2D game. The units and terrain are beautifully drawn in a cohesive style that lays emphasis on being cute over trying to pretend there is a third dimension involved. Tile transitions are seamless, thanks to what I believe is a careful blend of hand crafted borders and use of alpha transparency. The magic effects are brilliant. The combat animations are simple, but clever. Overall, there is little that could be done to make the graphics of this game any better than they already are.

Audio

The audio is very engaging and actually manages to engulf you into the game play if you have even a 2.1 speaker set. The sounds of combat are very realistic, my favourite being the clanking of the swords between the Elven archers and the Orcs.

Download URL: <http://www.wesnoth.org/wiki/Download>

HedgeWars



Genre: Action

Game play

HedgeWars is a multi-platform, free, turn-based, blast-'em-up in the style of Worms. It features a wide range of weapons, multiple maps, and excellent graphics and audio. It offers single player, multi-player, and (in theory) 'multi-player over the Internet' modes. It is a very well made multi-platform Worms clone that is free, fun, and offers some good production qualities.

Download URL: <http://linux.softpedia.com/get/GAMES-ENTERTAINMENT/Arcade/Hedgewars-28062.shtml>

